



Understanding PTSD

Trauma, its effects, and the path to healing

What Is PTSD?

Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder (PTSD) can develop after experiencing or witnessing a traumatic event — something life-threatening, deeply frightening, or overwhelming (accidents, violence, abuse, combat, disasters, sudden loss). PTSD is not a sign of weakness. It means your brain is trying to protect you from danger, even after the danger has passed.

Common Reactions After Trauma

Re-experiencing:

- Unwanted memories or flashbacks that feel like they're happening again
- Nightmares related to the trauma
- Strong reactions when reminded of the event

Avoidance:

- Avoiding places, people, or activities that are reminders
- Not wanting to talk or think about what happened
- Emotional numbness or disconnection

Negative Changes in Thinking and Mood:

- Difficulty feeling positive emotions or joy
- Negative beliefs ("I'm broken," "No one can be trusted")
- Blame, shame, or guilt; loss of interest in things you cared about

Hyperarousal (Being "On Guard"):

- Easily startled, constantly on alert
- Difficulty sleeping or concentrating
- Irritability, anger outbursts, or reckless behavior

This Is Your Brain Protecting You

After trauma, your brain stays in "survival mode" — scanning for danger and reacting as if the threat is still present. This alarm system kept you safe during the event but is now stuck "on." PTSD symptoms are normal reactions to abnormal experiences. With treatment, your brain can learn the danger has passed and begin to heal.

Treatment Works

- **Cognitive Processing Therapy (CPT):** Examine and reframe painful beliefs from the trauma (typically 12 sessions)
- **Prolonged Exposure (PE):** Gently face avoided memories and situations so they lose their power
- **EMDR:** Guided eye movements while recalling trauma help the brain process and store the memory differently
- **Medication:** Certain antidepressants reduce PTSD symptoms and are often used alongside therapy

Self-Care After Trauma

1. **Ground yourself:** Press feet into the floor, hold something cold, or focus on breathing. Remind yourself: "I am safe right now."
2. **Stick to a routine:** Predictable daily patterns help your nervous system feel safer.
3. **Limit news and triggers:** It's okay to step away from content that brings up difficult feelings.
4. **Move gently:** Walking, stretching, yoga, or swimming release tension stored in the body.
5. **Connect with safe people:** You don't have to share your story. Just being around people you trust helps.

Supporting a Loved One with PTSD

Do:

- Listen without judging — being present helps, even if you can't "fix" anything
- Be patient — recovery takes time and is rarely a straight line
- Learn about PTSD to understand what they're going through

Don't:

- Pressure them to talk about the trauma before they're ready
- Take irritability or withdrawal personally — it's a symptom, not about you
- Say "just get over it" or "it could have been worse"

When to Seek Help

If you or someone you know is in crisis, please reach out:

988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline	Call or text 988 (24/7)
Crisis Text Line	Text HOME to 741741
Emergency Services	Call 911
SAMHSA Helpline	1-800-662-4357 (free, 24/7)

You don't have to face this alone. Help is available and recovery is possible.